Mindfulness of Breath: Establishing an Anchor #1

Script for Guided Meditation

BASIC MINDFULNESS PRACTICE: BREATH (8 MINUTES)

Begin by establishing a comfortable posture in which you are both relaxed and alert.

If there's any obvious tightness or tension in the body that you can easily release, do so … Perhaps filling your body with the half smile of kindness …

Now bringing your attention to the fact of your body breathing. Noticing that it is always breathing, quite naturally …

Begin noticing where it's easiest to feel the breath. It might be a coolness you feel in your nostrils on the in-breath, or warmth on the upper lip with the out-breath. Or maybe you sense a swirling tingling in the back of the throat. It might be the rise and fall of your chest or belly … or it might be the sensations of the whole body breathing.

[Pause]

Wherever you find the breath easiest to feel, or most pleasant, resting your kind attention there …

If the breath is subtle or hard to feel, you can place a hand on your belly and feel the rise and fall of your belly in the palm of your hand. It's a beautiful way to stay with your breath.

[Long pause]

Now let yourself feel the next three in and out breaths. As you feel each breath, let the mind calm and the body relax.

[Pause]

Now feel three more.

[Pause]

Continuing with this relaxed and calming attention on the breath … Each time the attention wanders and you notice, gently bringing it back. Like training the puppy … no judgment. Simply a kindly return. Sit. Stay.

[Long pause]

This breath, just now.

[45 seconds]

If it's helpful, you can notice the beginning, and middle, and ending of the in-breath or rise … and the beginning, and middle, and end of the out-breath or the fall … Notice the space between breaths … rest yourself … relaxing with the breathing. Each breath arising and passing with mindful awareness.

[2 minutes]

Noticing where your attention is, and if it's drifted, gently returning to the sensations of breathing. As you feel each breath, let the mind calm and the body relax.

[Long pause]

Fully here, awake and at ease …

[Long pause, followed by ringing the bell.]

MEDITATION ANCHORS

It is helpful to select a home base or anchor that allows you to quiet and collect the mind, as well as to deepen embodied presence. Useful anchors are:

- The breath as it enters and leaves the nostrils, upper lip, and or throat
- Other sensations during breathing, such as the rise and fall of the chest or belly
- The whole body as it breathes
- Whole-body awareness without focus on breath
- The sensations of hands and feet
- 4–6 touch points in the body, such as buttocks, hands, etc.
- Seeing, hearing, sitting, touching
- Sounds; listening to all sounds within or around you
- Listening to and feeling one's entire experience (i.e., receiving sounds and sensations in awareness)

GENERAL GUIDELINES: LEADING MEDITATIONS

Create a safe and protected space that is without unnecessary distraction. This might mean asking people to turn off cell phones, closing doors, and putting up signs at an entrance letting people know that a meditation is going on.

Before starting the meditation, tell them what you will be doing—e.g., a six-minute guided meditation to help you establish awareness of breath.

Invite them to find a meditation posture that allows them to be comfortable and at ease. Give them choices—sitting on a cushion on the floor, sitting on a bench or the floor, in a chair, and (if appropriate or needed) standing or lying down.

Have them close their eyes if they are comfortable, or alternately, have them slightly open, with downward gaze. Again, it is wise to give choices.

For many meditations, it's helpful to begin by inviting them to sense their body and to relax areas of tightness and tension where it's easy to do so.

Guide their attention to the subject of the meditation, whether body, breath, lovingkindness, etc.

Be attentive to your pacing, speaking slowly and pausing regularly. Allow them ample time to open to their own experience, but not so much time (especially for beginners) that their minds will drift and lose track of the instructions.

Be attentive to the tone and quality of your voice. Speak from presence and heart—in a soft, clear, connected voice.

Make your language in the present moment: "Sensing your belly moving in the palm of your hand … noticing how thoughts arise and pass like clouds …"

For many teachers, it increases safety to make language invitational rather than directive: "You might explore bringing your attention inside your hands, feeling sensations from the inside out," versus, "Bring your attention inside your hands and feel sensations from the inside out."

Where appropriate, you might deepen engagement by asking questions: "Where is it easiest to feel your breath?" "What do you notice when you soften your hands? Tingling? Vibration? Pulsing? Warmth?"

Stay in touch with yourself AND with them throughout the meditation: inner attention that is mindful of your own sensations, etc. AND outer attention that is tracking how they are doing (i.e., restlessness, agitation, sleepiness, collectedness, calm).

Use phrases that evoke the spirit of care, tending love and kindness and compassion—e.g., "Bring a gentle and kind attention to any areas that feel unpleasant or difficult."

Speak to them periodically during the silent stretches of practice just to remind them gently to reconnect with what is here now. "You might notice what is happening right now," or, "Just this breath … and now this one … "

Give a one- to two-minute notice, e.g., "Soon we will be ending," or, "Just a couple minutes more."

Find a simple way to end. Include a bell if you like.

Check in with them afterwards—with the intention of normalizing difficulty, addressing confusion, and encouraging and affirming their process.